the hardware were put to use than let it gather rust. There were times when it also occurred to me that some people who did not want ISRO giving thrust to liquid propulsion systems would have derived great pleasure in seeing what was happening. Before my eyes, the Rolls Royce hydraulic laboratory was cannibalized.

Today, ISRO has a good test facility at Mahendragiri in Tamil Nadu. Had we found a place like that in 1971, the lab would have continued to be an envy of the world. Still, the Rolls Royce lab, forty-two years vintage, could have been incomparable for its simplicity and functional efficiency. After the development of Vikas engine, all we have been doing is improvising on it, the cryogenic engine being an exception. Now, if India wants to develop a totally new concept rocket engine, we would have to set up a lab like the one Cleaver so generously gave us away, only to be wasted.

This could have never happened if Sarabhai was alive. For he was the man who sent me to Spadeadam to take a look at the facility, though he wouldn't have dreamed of Cleaver gifting us the lab. Had Sarabhai lived a couple of more years longer, the Rolls Royce lab would have found a second life on a new campus in India. If a new campus was hard to come by, I was sure, Sarabhai would have set it up at one of the educational institutions, probably IISc, Bangalore, in which he had an abiding interest.

He had close ties with the then IISc director Satish Dhawan, who succeeded Sarabhai as the ISRO chairman, after M G K Menon held the post of interim chairman for less than six months. Probably Sarabhai saw a crucial role for Dhawan in India's space programme. When Dhawan visited TERLS sometime in the late 1960s, Sarabhai asked Dhawan to visit the high altitude rocket test facility at Tennessee, US. Dhawan did as directed and submitted a report to Sarabhai.